Joker of Academics

Research on the micro-expression of limbs and the delivery of liquid power in the relationship between contemporary postgraduate guidance and learning

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Abstract With the continuous expansion of the scale of higher education, the cultivation of graduate students has been alienated from the simple " knowledge production " to the all-round " guided learning ecological service. " This study jumps out of the traditional laboratory research perspective and focuses on the informal academic interaction scene - ' pour water in the office ', which has long been neglected by the academic community but occurs frequently. Through six years of service observation, this study found that pouring water into leaders (tutors) has evolved into a complex ' body discipline technology ' and ' implicit power game '. This paper puts forward the concept of " liquid academic capital " for the first time, and constructs the " gradient model of water pouring ability, " trying to reveal the logic of academic resource replacement, the internal competition situation and the deep structure of graduate students ' emotional labor behind a cup of hot water. The study believes that the precise control of water temperature, the standardized posture of the end cup, the timing of observation, and the ability to predict the continuation of the cup together constitute the last ' technical barrier ' for contemporary graduate students before graduation. This study aims to provide a new analytical framework for understanding the micro-power operation in China 's localized academic ecology.

Keywords Relationship between tutors and students ; body discipline ; pouring water politics ; nonverbal communication ; graduate student survival strategy

1. Introduction

In the daily operation of Chinese academia, the laboratory, the departmental office, and the supervisor's personal office are not merely sites of knowledge production; they are also arenas for the enactment of micro-power structures and hubs of intense affective labor. Within this context, "pouring water" — a task seemingly relegated to the realm of low-level logistical support — has, almost imperceptibly, become "academicized," "ritualized," and "hierarchicalized," emerging as a sociological proposition worthy of in-depth investigation.

Conventional wisdom posits that a graduate student pouring water for their supervisor is a simple embodiment of respect for teachers and scholarship, a natural continuation of the Chinese pedagogical tradition. However, against the backdrop of downward pressure from the "up-or-out" system, the rising annual rate of delayed graduations, and increasingly strained supervisor-student relationships, the act of pouring water has long transcended mere etiquette. It has evolved into a "high-stakes performance" characterized by profound uncertainty and a form of "daily disciplinary practice."

The underlying logic of academic power dynamics that this reveals urgently requires the attention and analysis of the scholarly community. Why does this simple physical act generate such intense anxiety and involution among graduate students? What symbolic meanings does it carry? How does it become intricately interwoven with the allocation of academic resources, the supervisor's personal preferences, and intra-laboratory competition? This study, guided by these questions, seeks to unravel the "academic-political code hidden within a cup of water."

From a theoretical perspective, research on supervisor-student relationships is extensive. However, it predominantly focuses on "hardcore" aspects such as publishing papers, applying for grants, and experimental guidance. Scholarly attention to the mundane, trivialized interactions like pouring water, cleaning, or running errands remains almost non-existent — a veritable "dehydration" of academic inquiry. Foucault's theory of "disciplinary power" offers crucial insights for understanding this phenomenon: power resides not only

in grand institutional structures but also permeates the capillaries of daily life, shaping individuals into "docile bodies" through countless minor rituals and exercises. Pouring water stands as a quintessential practice of this micro-physics of power.

Scholars have noted a triple tension inherent in contemporary supervisor-student dynamics: first, the entanglement of academic guidance and affective labor; second, the interweaving of resource allocation and personal favor; and third, the interplay between institutional discipline and individual resistance. These tensions are particularly pronounced in daily interactions, and the act of pouring water serves as a concentrated site for their performance.

The recent phenomenon of the "Academic Bottom Journal" provides a crucial contemporary context for understanding the issue of pouring water. While seemingly purely satirical, this phenomenon actually reflects the collective anxiety and rebellious sentiment among early-career researchers. This study, continuing the critical spirit and deconstructive approach of the "Academic Bottom Journal," seeks to re-examine the seemingly "useless" act of pouring water by placing it at the heart of academic production. It explores the delicate balance it represents between "affective labor" and "resource exchange," thereby revealing the underlying logic of academic politics concealed within these daily trivialities.

2. Theoretical framework and research design

2.1 Definition of core concepts

This study innovatively proposes the concept of Liquid Academic Capital. It refers to a non-entity exchange of graduate students by controlling the temperature, flow rate, delivery time and accompanying microexpressions, body language and emotional input of the liquid in exchange for the implicit favor of the tutor and subsequent academic resources (such as paper signature, project participation, graduation recommendation, employment recommendation, etc.). The capital has the characteristics of strong liquidity, long accumulation cycle and unstable exchange rate, as shown in figure 1.

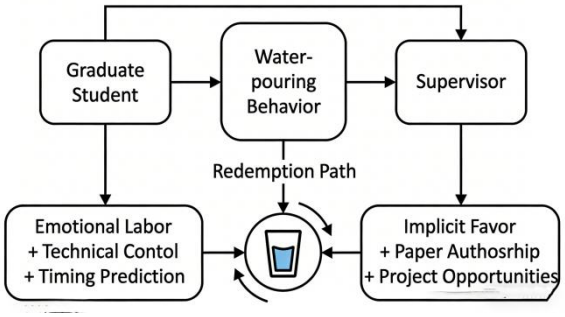

Figure 1 The flow path of liquid academic capital

Water-Pouring Field refers to the microscopic interaction space formed around the behavior of pouring water, including tutors, graduate students, peers, drinking water equipment, tea utensils and other elements. This field is not only a physical space, but also a social space and a symbolic space.

The Water-Pouring Competence Gradient Model is an analysis model based on empirical data. It divides the ability of graduate students to pour water into four levels : primary, intermediate, advanced, and master. Each level corresponds to different technical requirements and resource conversion capabilities.

2.2 Research methods

This study used a combination of ' pseudo-participatory observation ' (that is, the researcher is the person who poured water) and ' semi-structured sour interview '. The interviewees cover liberal arts, science and engineering master 's and doctoral students.

3. The multiple meanings of water as a thing

3.1 Teacher-student relationship in the western context

To understand the phenomenon of pouring water in China, we first need to examine it from the perspective of cross-cultural comparison. In the context of Western culture, the relationship between teachers and students is more inclined to contract and specialization. The relationship between graduate students and tutors is based on a clear boundary of rights and responsibilities : tutors provide academic guidance, graduate students complete research tasks, and both sides conduct academic exchanges through regular meetings.

It is worth noting that in the western academic environment, there is very little obligation for graduate students to pour water for tutors. On the one hand, this is due to the emphasis on individual independence in Western culture. On the other hand, it is also closely related to eating habits. Westerners are more accustomed to drinking direct ice water or coffee machine for self-service, which objectively blocks the generation of " hot water service, " a localized teacher-student interaction model that needs continuous attention and repeated supplementation. In contrast, in the domestic academic circle, ' drinking more hot water ' is not only a universal antidote to physical discomfort, but also a hotbed of tutor authority and a medium of emotional connection. The hot water needs to be burned, the fire needs to be mastered, and the remaining water needs to be observed, which provides a long technical action display time and frequent interaction opportunities for ' waiting '.

3.2 Research on the relationship between local guidance and learning

Domestic scholars ' research on the relationship between guidance and learning has undergone a

paradigm shift from ethical narrative to power analysis. Early research mostly started from the traditional ethics of " master and apprentice as father and son, " emphasizing that graduate students ' respect and obedience to tutors is an inevitable requirement for academic inheritance. However, with the expansion of postgraduate enrollment and the increase of scientific research pressure, the mentoring relationship is increasingly showing the employment color of ' boss and employee '.

There are three tensions in the contemporary guidance relationship : one is the mixture of academic guidance and emotional labor, the other is the interweaving of resource allocation and human interaction, and the third is the game between institutional discipline and individual resistance. These tensions are particularly evident in daily interactions, and pouring water is the concentrated performance field of these tensions.

4. Research finding

4.1 Stage theory of pouring water

Through the coding analysis of the grounded theory of the interview text, this study found that the water pouring behavior of graduate students showed significant stage characteristics. This feature is highly correlated with the years of enrollment, the status of teachers and the expectation of academic output.

4.1.1 Passive calling and Trial-and-error learning

When a freshman enters the teacher 's door, he often lacks a clear understanding of the " hidden rule " of pouring water. At this time, their water pouring behavior has three typical characteristics :

The first is passivity. Usually, action is taken only when the tutor or brother explicitly calls - ' little X, help me pour a glass of water ' -. In various meetings, they do not take the initiative to pour water on the superior, and are often labeled as ignorant. As a participant in pouring water, when observing the first-year graduate students pouring water, they are often nervous and their hands are shaking. After pouring, they do not know whether to put down and go, or stand.

Then the technology is rusty. The water temperature control error can reach ± 10 °C, which is expressed as ' either hot mouth or too much tea '. Freshmen are often in a passive state of pouring water, so the first cup of water poured to the instructor is often 100 degrees hot water, so that the end of the meeting, the cup of water is full. Of course, there are exceptions. The water is bright and hot, and the participants can still drink quickly.

Finally, there is a lack of supporting speech. Usually only say ' teacher, give you water ', lack of emotional added value and context adaptation. Many graduate students do not take this opportunity to brush their sense of existence.

There is almost no visible correlation between the dumping behavior and academic output at this stage, and students are in the survival mode of " living as well. "

4.1.2 Active observation and skillful improvement

After entering the second year of postgraduate study, most graduate students began to realize the importance of pouring water and took the initiative to improve relevant skills. The characteristics of this stage include :

The first is active observation. They no longer wait for the call, but by observing the teacher 's drinking habits (such as what to drink, how often to drink, and under what circumstances to drink) to predict the needs. Then the water temperature control accuracy is improved. The graduate students in this stage can control the water temperature stably within ± 2 °C, and achieve the ideal state of ' drinking at the entrance '. The second is the upgrading of supporting words. They began to integrate emotional care and situational adaptation, such as ' teacher, be careful and hot '.

At this stage, the dumping behavior began to have a weak correlation with academic resources, which was manifested as ' the teacher occasionally praised me for being careful at the group meeting ', but there was still no obvious return on substantive resources (such as the signature of the paper), which was in the stage of ' being familiar '.

4.1.3 Predictive continuation cup and emotional investment

The third stage of research is the ' high-order form ' display period of water pouring behavior. At this time, graduate students are faced with the key choice of graduation, employment or further study, and the behavior of pouring water also changes qualitatively.

The first is the predictive continuation cup. They can get up in advance to continue the water when the tutor cup will be empty. This ' pre-judgment ' is not only based on the observation of water consumption, but also on the deep understanding of the tutor 's working state. Then the water temperature control. Make the water temperature reach a suitable stable output. This temperature will not be cooled by placing too long, nor will it be scalded by just boiled. It is an ideal carrier of ' liquid academic capital '. Then the emotional depth of the supporting words is strengthened, and the opportunity to speak actively is taken to solve some of its own problems and respond to some situations.

The correlation between water pouring behavior and academic output at this stage becomes significant. Most dumpers can be in a comfortable environment in the team and even bet on a good future.

4.1.4 Drain capacity gradient model

Based on the above analysis, this paper constructs the ' pour water capacity gradient model ', as shown in Figure 2. Table 1 explains the core content of the model in detail.

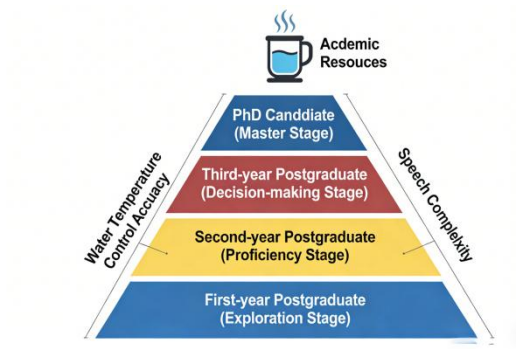

Figure 2. Water-Pouring Competence Gradient Model

Table 1. The four stages of the "water-pouring" practice in supervisor-student dynamics

Stage	Frequency of Pouring	Water Temperature Status	Core Competency	Accompanying Discourse	Expected Academic Output
Exploratory phase	Passive (Responds to summons)	Scalding hot	Steadying the cup	Here's your water.	Survival
Proficiency phase	Active (Observes and acts)	Drinkable upon serving	Seizing the right moment	Professor, here is your water	Capable of co-authorship
Decision-making phase	Anticipatory (Proactive refilling)	Always perfectly judged	Reading the subtle cues	Professor, careful, it's hot.	Direct PhD entry, Retention in lab, Recommendation letter
Mastery phase	Action through inaction	Temperature resonates with emotional state	Full responsibility for teaware & tea management	Conveying care through silence	Automatic resource allocation

4.2 Symbolization of water

Liquid itself also has a strong sense of social stratification. This study found that different drinks correspond to different teacher status and teacher-student intimacy.

4.2.1 Direct drinking of pure water

Direct drinking of pure water is the standard of the underlying labor force. Pure water / direct drinking water is usually poured by students themselves, a symbol of ' academic horse ' only thirst, no need to taste. When the tutor drinks such water, it often means that the teacher-student relationship stays at the level of ' pure working relationship '.

4.2.2 Bulk tea

Bulk green tea is an entry-level waiter. When the tutor starts to ask the students to help make tea, it means that the students have obtained the initial qualification of " indoor service. " However, at this time, the tea is usually ordinary bulk tea, and the symbolic relationship is still in the ' trial period '.

4.2.3 Exclusive tea

Exclusive tea belongs to the symbol of the heart. When the tutor starts to let students take tea from a specific teapot, or even let students buy tea on their behalf, it means that the students have entered the ' heart circle '. Students at this level will not only pour water, but also understand water temperature, baking and tea tasting.

4.2.4 Hand brewed coffee

Hand brewed coffee is a symbol of ultimate trust. Hand brewed coffee or kung fu tea is the highest form of liquid interaction. This not only requires students to pour water, but also to master complex brewing skills. The whole process itself is an ' academic ceremony '. Students who can drink the hand-made coffee of their tutors are usually regarded as ' great disciples ' or ' academic heirs ' by default.

4.3 Competition for ' right to pour water '

When there are many graduate students in the teacher 's door, the area around the water dispenser / kettle becomes a hidden strategic location. This study finds that the competition for ' right to pour water ' presents a complex interactive mode.

4.3.1 The phenomenon of ' academic cutting '

Who first noticed the gap of the tutor 's cup and got up at the first time, who occupied the commanding heights of morality and ethics at that moment. This action was dubbed by the interviewee as " academic cut. " Once the brothers and sisters take the initiative, the latecomers often fall into the embarrassing situation of ' getting up at this time is suspected of overstepping, and continuing to sit like sitting needle felt '.

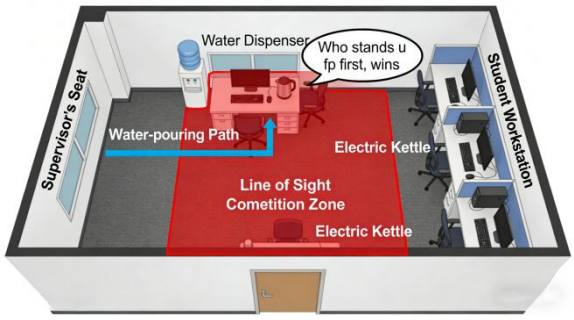

Figure 3 The schematic diagram of the space competition for the right to pour water

Here is a typical case. For example, there are five people in the office, and the nearest water dispenser to the tutor 's desk is the location of the master brother. Each time the teacher cup empty, the master brother swish up on the stand, the remaining four people can only pretend to read the literature. Once Master Brother was absent, one of them took the opportunity to rush up and pour the water, and came back to find that the other three people 's eyes had changed.

4.3.2 The ' inverted water scheduling ' system

In some divisions, pouring water even evolved into implicit or explicit scheduling system. For example, who is the last to the office who is responsible for the day 's pouring water. But then everyone began to roll who arrived early, and finally poured water became the exclusive welfare of the earliest people.

4.3.3 The hidden transaction of ' pouring water for resources '

Some graduate students will use the opportunity to spend time alone with their tutors, and then put forward academic appeals, such as paper revision, purchase of experimental materials, etc.

4.4 The deep structure of emotional labor

Hawkshire 's emotional labor theory provides an important perspective for understanding the phenomenon of pouring water.[1] This study found that pouring water is not only a kind of manual labor and skilled labor, but also a highly intensive emotional labor.

4.4.1 Surface performance and deep performance

Precise emotional management is needed in the process of pouring water. Even if the heart is full of anxiety, dissatisfaction or fatigue, it is necessary to show the expression of ' willing ' and ' meticulous and thoughtful ' at the moment of pouring water. This surface performance may be internalized into deep performance over time. For example, pouring water for a long time will really have a sense of responsibility for the tutor to ' take care of him '.

4.4.2 Emotional exhaustion and self-doubt

However, continuous emotional labor also brings significant psychological costs. The moment of solitude after pouring water often falls into self-doubt : ' Am I here to read or to be a nanny ? s sending these papers because of my academic ability or because my water is well poured ? '

4.4.3 The fracture and reconstruction of identity

The practice of pouring water also profoundly affects the self-identity of graduate students. On the one hand, long-term wait-and-see labor may lead to the separation of the identities of ' academics ' and ' servers ' ; on the other hand, some graduate students reconstruct their self-identity by ' technicalizing ' and ' academicizing ' the pouring water - ' I am an academic person who knows the world. '

Figure 4 The inner theater of the drowning man

4.5 The supplement of tutor perspective

From the perspective of the tutor, there is a clear differentiation in the behavior of graduate students pouring water. The first is the ' take it for granted ' type. They believe that pouring water is the proper meaning of respecting teachers. For example, ' When I was a PhD student, it was common to pour water, run errands, and pick up children for my tutor. The students are much more comfortable now. 'Then it 's ' doesn 't matter ' type. They have a neutral attitude towards pouring water. Such mentors don 't matter, they pour me drink, not pour me pour yourself. I pay more attention to the quality of the paper. The second is the ' even discomfort ' type. Such tutors are embarrassed or even disgusted by pouring water. Students pour water will make it uncomfortable, especially standing and waiting to drink that. The last is the ' evaluation basis ' type. They admit that pouring water will affect the evaluation, but the way of influence is complex. He will not be given a high score because of who pours more water, but if a student does not even have basic politeness and observation, such tutors will doubt whether he can do a good job in research. Ultimately, pouring water reflects attitudes and

emotional intelligence.

4.6 Extended scene of pouring water

The study also found that watering behavior has extended from the office to more scenarios. Such as academic conferences. When accompanying the tutor to attend the meeting, the graduate students should not only pour water on the tutor, but also sometimes pour water on the academic predecessors in the same field. This is called ' academic diplomacy pouring water ' by the interviewees. Another example is the dinner party. The pouring of water / wine on the dinner party is a more complex knowledge, involving multiple factors such as seating, toasting time, and wine selection. Or on the way out. When accompanying on business trips, graduate students often have to bear the whole service from booking tickets to carrying luggage to pouring water.

These extended scenarios put forward higher requirements for the comprehensive quality of graduate students, and also make the pouring water expand from ' office skills ' to ' full-scene survival skills '.

5. Discuss

On the basis of empirical analysis, this section attempts to answer a more fundamental question : why does a simple water action require graduate students to invest so much cognitive resources, time and energy, and emotional labor ?

5.1 Internalization of discipline

Foucault 's discipline theory provides a profound insight into understanding this phenomenon. By constantly accepting the service of pouring water, Tutor confirms his position of authority without saying a word ; students strengthen their recognition of the hierarchical order by repeatedly bending down, cups, hand delivery, and smiling gaze. The more fluent and natural this set of actions is, the higher the student 's tameness to the existing academic system is.

More importantly, when pouring water becomes a ' habit ' or even an ' instinct ', discipline is transformed from external coercion into self-technology - students no longer need the instructions of their mentors, but instead take the initiative to observe, predict, and execute. This ' automation ' is precisely the highest level of power operation.

5.2 The Blurred Boundary between "Affection" and "Duty"

In the normative academic system, the contract clarifies the boundary of rights and responsibilities between teachers and students. However, in the local context, due to the traditional ethics of " teachers and students are like fathers and sons, " the academic evaluation system is often mixed with a lot of private emotions. Tutor gives more names and recommendations to a student by ' feeling ', and this ' feeling ' is largely derived from the satisfaction of daily service.

This has caused the boundary between ' sentiment ' and ' duty ' to be blurred. Is pouring water within the student 's ' duty ' or extra ' duty ' ? This question is difficult to answer in reality. For example, if students take the initiative to pour water, the tutor 's heart will be warmer.

5.3 Survival strategy under uncertainty

From the perspective of students, the strengthening of water pouring behavior is closely related to the high uncertainty of academic environment. The recommendation and support of tutors often play a decisive role in many links such as project application, paper publication and graduation defense. Under this uncertainty, students tend to adopt the strategy of ' excessive obedience ' -doing more is better than doing less, so as not to ' lose points ' at the critical moment.

5.4 The micro projection of academic ecology

From a more macro perspective, the phenomenon of pouring water is a micro-projection of China 's academic ecology. It reflects the complex interweaving of " hard index " and " soft relationship " in the academic evaluation system, reflects the continuation of the human society in the academic field, and also exposes the structural problem of unequal power in the guiding relationship.

As the phenomenon of " academic back issues " reveals, young researchers use absurdity against absurdity, with deconstruction to expose hypocrisy behind, is a more healthy, more transparent, more professional academic ecology of deep desire.

6. Conclusion and suggestion

This study academically demonstrates the huge metaphor of the tiny practice of ' pouring water ' in the academic career of graduate students. It is neither pure physical labor nor simple respect for teachers, but a kind of 'body micro-expression 'and 'survival strategy 'formed under the background of high involution. Through the above analysis, the following core conclusions are drawn :

First, pouring water has evolved from simple etiquette behavior to complex ' body discipline technology ' and ' hidden power game field '. Graduate students ' practice of pouring water follows a clear law of phased development, from passive implementation to active prediction, from rough technology to precise control, from simple service to emotional investment.

Second, there is a hidden relationship between the behavior of pouring water and the allocation of academic resources. Although this correlation is difficult to quantify, respondents generally acknowledged that

the ' pour-in-place ' peer has certain advantages in terms of paper signature, project participation, and graduation recommendation.

Third, pouring water is an important carrier of graduate students ' emotional labor, which has a profound impact on graduate students ' emotional state and self-identity. Continuous emotional effort may lead to exhaustion, or it may form a new identity through ' skill-based ' reconstruction.

Fourth, the phenomenon of pouring water is a micro-projection of China 's local academic ecology, reflecting the complex interweaving of ' hard index ' and ' soft relationship ' in the evaluation system, as well as the survival strategy of young researchers in an uncertain environment.

Based on the research findings, this paper suggests that graduate students should establish a clear sense of boundary and seek a balance between respecting teachers and maintaining self-esteem. Pour water can be regarded as a window to observe interpersonal relationships and exercise emotional intelligence, but it should not be over-invested, nor should it be regarded as a shortcut to academic success. The tutor should reflect on the way he exercises his power and avoid unconsciously strengthening the hierarchical symbols behind the pouring water.

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